Fund, with the state matching industry contributions; and 12 AI incubators with funding support of up to Rs 1 crore each.

Inevitably, the conceptualisation does not miss out on the spiffy, highrise vocabulary that attends to most emerging tech, especially in the way it interacts with global finance. So you get a planned 300-acre 'Innovation City' in Navi Mumbai, a startup accelerator called 'M Hub', Global Capability Centre Parks in Mumbai, Pune, Nagpur, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar (Aurangabad) and Nashik to attract R&D and backoffice operations from global tech firms.

But the policy then also flows ingeniously into how all this can make sense for local small entrepreneurs. Take the way the policy promises to help at least one AI startup grow into a unicorn; up to Rs 1.25 crore plus an additional 25 per cent financial assistance for women-led startups; even subsidies to MSMEs to adopt AI, a layer that marks a bold first anywhere.

Yet, all these means of integrating AI into the local economy may pale in front of one: building datasets and tools in Marathi and other local languages so people can actually use the technology. The 'MahaChatur' chatbot, with which the state will converse with its citizens, is a highlight. That comes with a tacit subtext: global AI is out of quality data, learning newer languages is its way of enriching its proprietary models. The question is: who will own the data? ■

Takeaways

- **Devendra Fadnavis regime rolls out ingenious AI policy that sees tech as harbinger, not destroyer of jobs**
- **A hardware backbone, top training centres, six 'AI City' hubs. Plus incentives for women-led startups, MSMEs**
- **The official 'MahaChatur' chatbot unveils the clincher: AI in Marathi and other local languages, to ease adoption**



▶ GUJARAT

ONE COUNTY FOR CATS OF ALL STRIPES

A tiger wanders in from nearby Madhya Pradesh and settles down—offering a local sighting after 40 years. But the excitement is muted by caution as conservationists ponder the complexities

By **Jumana Shah**

IT'S THE ONE STATE THAT FAMOUSLY has exclusive bragging rights on owning the biggest of the big cats within India, even figuratively. Now, as if with a nod of its feline head at recent political developments, the Bengal Tiger, too, has fallen to the charms of this western state. To be sure, it's a homecoming. The tiger did once roam Gujarat's forests, but was declared locally extinct four decades ago. So, when a solitary tiger travelled through the Vindhyachal ranges, a historic forest pathway linking Madhya Pradesh's tiger-rich reserves to the Ratanmahal Wildlife Sanctuary in Dahod, eastern Gujarat, it was a reclaiming of lost